Magna visit

FIELD BRIEF · WRITTEN 27 SEP 2026 · FOR T

What to ask, what to do, what to bring back - and why each one matters to the program. Type into the grey boxes and save, or print this and write in them.

IF YOU ONLY DO ONE THING

Photograph two skins they say ARE a match, and two they say are NOT - with a tape measure and a grey card in the frame, all four shot in the same spot under the same light.

That one act unblocks the biggest stuck piece of this project. Everything else here is worth having; that is worth the trip.

Why we need Magna

The people at Magna already do this, by hand, every day - and we have been guessing at how. The program decides two hides match by measuring two things from a photograph: how big the scales are, and what colour the leather is. Both were our idea of what matters. Three guesses in particular could be wrong:

1. We assume scale size is worth measuring precisely. The trade matches on shade, on cut and on pattern by eye. That might mean we have found something new, or that it is irrelevant.
2. We assume that if two hides match, every piece cut from one matches every piece cut from the other. A hide varies across its own surface, so that may be nonsense.
3. We have no idea where "close enough" stops. Nobody has ever shown the program an example of a match and an example of a rejection.

We are not auditing them and not asking them to change anything. If a question feels like prying, skip it - the photographs matter far more than the answers.

KIT Bring

- [ ] A tape measure or steel rule - essential, see the photo rules
- [ ] A grey card, 8x10 inch (DGK 18% gray card, about $10). Size is the point: a credit-card size card is too few pixels to average a colour from in a whole-skin frame.
- [ ] Your phone, with plenty of storage free
- [ ] Calipers, if you can lay hands on a pair
- [ ] Something to write on

ASK The cobblers

Ask whoever actually picks the hides. If you can, ask more than one person - two people disagreeing about what matters would itself be a valuable finding.

The core seven

1 **When you pick two hides as a match, what exactly are you looking for?**

Let them talk before narrowing it down. What they mention first, unprompted, is the most useful part.

ANSWER

2 **Are you measuring the scales - ruler, compass, calipers - or judging by eye?**

Matters most. The program's entire scale-measuring pipeline assumes this is a real, precise judgement.

ANSWER

3 **If two hides match, is it safe to assume every piece cut from one will match every piece cut from the other?**

Or does it depend where on the hide a piece comes from? This decides the design of a feature we are about to build.

ANSWER

4 **What is the first thing you look at that rules a skin OUT?**

The program can only rule out on species, cut and finish. If their first disqualifier is a scar or a grade, we are missing it.

ANSWER

5 **How big an area needs to match?**

A patch, a whole panel, or the area a piece gets cut from? We measure one small patch.

ANSWER

6 **If two skins match, can you make several pairs of sneakers from them, or just one?**

It changes what a match is worth, and what the program should report.

ANSWER

7 **Anything else about how you pick - including the parts that are hard to put into words.**

ANSWER

If the conversation allows

8 **How do you describe a colour to each other?**

By the supplier's name off the chart ("Cognac"), by eye, or by holding it against something?

ANSWER

9 **Do you use grades?**

The trade grades exotic skins 1-4, alligator 1-5, on defect count. Matching, buying, or neither?

ANSWER

10 **Have you heard the term "shade sorting"?**

The garment trade's name for grouping dyed material so panels from different lots do not show a difference.

ANSWER

11 **Does a pair of alligator skins make two pairs of boots - one from the matching tails, one from the bellies?**

We read this and built a rule on it. Worth hearing it confirmed or corrected.

ANSWER

12 **Under what light do you judge colour?**

Daylight, a particular lamp, a light box? It tells us how far our photographs can be trusted.

ANSWER

13 **How long does picking a match usually take?**

If it is quick for them, the program may be solving a problem they do not have.

ANSWER

DO While you are there

Doing beats asking. People are far better at showing their process than describing it.

- [ ] Watch someone pick a match, start to finish, without interrupting. Ask your questions afterwards.

WHAT YOU SAW - ORDER OF ACTIONS, WHERE THEY STOOD, HOW LONG

- [ ] Ask what they just rejected, and why. Rejections tell us more than acceptances.

WHAT THEY REJECTED, AND WHY

- [ ] Measure a swatch patch on the supplier's sample card - one printed colour square, in millimetres.

PATCH SIZE IN MM, AND WHOSE CHART

- [ ] Measure real scales with calipers on a skin they called a good match. Note species, cut and where.

SPECIES, CUT, WHERE ON THE SKIN, MM

- [ ] Note the lighting wherever they judge colour, and photograph it if that is not awkward.

LIGHTING

- [ ] Find out who decides. One person, or a consensus? Do disagreements happen?

WHO DECIDES

- [ ] Ask whether they would look at ranked results later and say whether they would have picked them.

THEIR ANSWER, AND WHO TO SEND IT TO

GET Files to ask for

Ask for what is easy. Anything touching their intellectual property, do not push - note that it exists and we will ask properly later.

- [ ] The supplier's swatch chart images, high-resolution files rather than photos of a screen. 413 transcribed names would become 413 measured standards.

GOT IT? WHO TO CHASE

- [ ] Any grading or quality standard they work to - a chart, spec sheet, supplier document.

GOT IT? WHO TO CHASE

- [ ] Any existing photographs of hides they already keep.

GOT IT? WHO TO CHASE

- [ ] Pantone numbers, LAB values, a spectrophotometer readout - anything numeric.

GOT IT? WHO TO CHASE

- [ ] Pattern files for a sneaker (DXF, SVG, AI). Ask carefully, only if it comes up naturally - this is their IP.

GOT IT? WHO TO CHASE

- [ ] Do they shoot their own photographs of skins? If so, how, and could we see an example?

GOT IT? WHO TO CHASE

SHOOT The photographs

The most valuable thing you can bring back. The rules matter more than the quantity.

Every photo, no exceptions

1. A tape measure or rule flat in the frame, beside the skin. Without it a photograph has no scale. This is the one rule that makes a photo useless if broken.
2. A grey card in the frame, flat, in the same light as the skin.
3. Straight down, flat. Shot at an angle, the scale changes across the frame.
4. Even light, no glare. A bright highlight loses all colour where it lands.
5. Both skins of a pair in the same place, same light, same session.
6. Grain side up - the outside, the scales - unless it is suede.

If you could not get a grey card

Matching compares two hides against each other, not against an absolute standard. A reference that is imperfect but identical in every photo still removes the lighting difference between shots, which is the error we are actually fighting. In order of preference: grey mat board, a neutral grey paint chip, then plain white paper as a last resort (it carries optical brighteners and reads blue).

One object, in every photo, never swapped mid-session. Photograph it once on its own as well.

WHAT YOU USED AS THE GREY REFERENCE

Three shots per skin

- [ ] The whole skin, flat, everything in frame, rule and grey card included
- [ ] A close-up of a clean patch of scales - sharp, in focus, scales filling most of the frame, rule still in shot
- [ ] A close-up of the area they would actually cut the visible pieces from

The sets that matter, in order

- [ ] A confirmed MATCH. Two skins they say go together, both shot properly.

WHICH SKINS, PHOTO NUMBERS, AND WHAT PRODUCT THEY WOULD GO INTO

- [ ] A confirmed REJECTION. Two skins they say do NOT go together - ask why.

WHICH SKINS, PHOTO NUMBERS, AND THE REASON GIVEN

- [ ] A genuine close call. The single most informative thing possible - it is the actual borderline.

WHICH SKINS, PHOTO NUMBERS, AND WHAT MADE IT CLOSE

- [ ] More of the above. Three or four of each would be strong; ten of each exceptional.

RUNNING TALLY

Variations, if the skins are there

- [ ] Different species - caiman, alligator, python, ostrich, stingray
- [ ] Different cuts - belly, tail, hornback, leg, full quill. The program refuses to pair a tail with a belly.
- [ ] Different finishes - glossy, matte, suede. The program refuses to pair a suede with a glossy.
- [ ] A glossy skin specifically, shot carefully to avoid glare
- [ ] A skin with a visible scar or defect, if they will allow it

LOG Photo log

Photographs travel separately, at full resolution, straight off the camera - putting them inside a document re-compresses exactly the detail we need to measure. This page is what ties them back to the answers: note each file's name or number and which skin it shows.

PHOTO FILE OR NUMBER	WHICH SKIN, WHICH SET, AND WHICH OF THE THREE SHOTS

If the visit is short and you have to choose: photographs of a match and a rejection, shot to the rules above, beat every answer in this document.
Words about a process can be re-asked over a phone. Two skins side by side under one light, with a rule and a grey card in the frame, cannot.